

Comply: API Submission (Germany)



Version Control

Version	Date	Author	Details
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1. Introduction

1.1. Purpose of this section

The purpose of this document is to provide guidance and instruction on how Comply users submit Returns for Germany using an API. It will cover the steps required for Configuring Comply and for both Successful and Failed Submission flows.

1.2. Overview

To exchange data with the German Tax authority (via ERiC), you need one or more certificates which are password protected and as such it is important to have the required PIN/Password. For the API submission, the correct combination of PFX Certificate & PIN/Password must be added in the backend of Comply.

This step is currently configured by opening a JIRA ticket with the support desk to have this added.

1.2.1. Return Types

All Return Types can be submitted via API.

- VAT Returns
- VIES
- Annual Returns
- VAT Advanced Payments

2. Tax Office Authorisation (External Steps)

In order to submit your filings digitally (Via API), the client must complete the following:

1. Register on Mein Elster <https://www.elster.de/eportal/login/softpse>
2. Request a PFX Certificate and PIN.

This certificate is the secure authorisation which allows comply to communicate digitally with the German Tax Authority on the clients behalf when submitting returns.

3. Send the PFX Certificate and PIN to TBI **via Encrypted Email.**

The screenshot shows the ELSTER login interface. The header includes the ELSTER logo, the text 'Ihr Online-Finanzamt', and navigation links for 'Hilfe', 'Chat', and language selection 'DE' and 'EN'. There are buttons for 'Benutzerkonto erstellen' and 'Login'. A sidebar on the left lists various services: 'Mein ELSTER', 'Mein Benutzerkonto', 'Formulare & Leistungen', 'Benutzergruppen', and 'Weitere Softwareprodukte'. The main content area is titled 'Login mit' and features a list of login methods: 'Zertifikatsdatei' (selected), 'ElsterSecure (Neu)', 'Personalausweis', 'Sicherheitsstick', and 'Signaturkarte'. The 'Zertifikatsdatei' section includes a file selection button 'Auswählen', a 'Durchsuchen' button, a password field with a toggle icon, and a 'Login' button. Below the login fields, there is a link for 'Zertifikatsdatei verloren oder Zertifikat abgelaufen? Passwort vergessen?'. At the bottom, a section titled 'Wo finde ich meine heruntergeladene Zertifikatsdatei?' provides instructions on how to find the downloaded certificate file.

3. Configuration (In Comply)

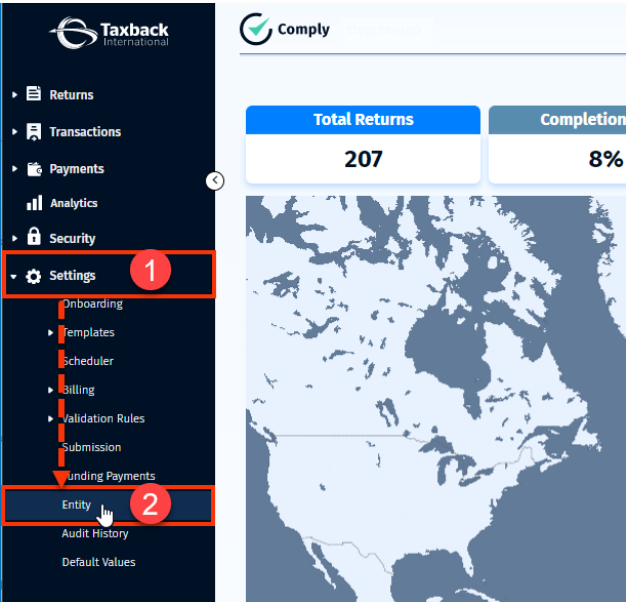
If a Tax Consultant is filing on your behalf, then no action is required here.

If you are filing on your own behalf, or if a Foreign Tax Consultant is filing for you, then some configuration steps are required.

3.1. Select Submitter Information

The XML files generated for each Submitter Type vary in type and consist of different data.

Selecting the Submitter Type here ensures the correct XML template which will be generated.



The screenshot shows the Taxback Comply interface. On the left is a dark blue sidebar with a white navigation menu. The menu items are: Returns, Transactions, Payments, Analytics, Security, Settings (highlighted with a red box and a red circle with the number 1), Onboarding, Templates, Scheduler, Billing, Validation Rules, Submission, Funding Payments, Entity (highlighted with a red box and a red circle with the number 2), Audit History, and Default Values. The main content area is light blue and shows a 'Total Returns' section with a value of 207 and a 'Completion' section with a value of 8%. Below these is a world map. To the right of the screenshot is a blue box with white text containing two numbered steps.

1. Go to **Settings**.
2. Open the **Entity** sub-menu.

This opens the **Entity Details** page.

1. In the Entity section, select the relevant **Entity**.
2. Click the **Jurisdiction** in the Jurisdiction Country Details section.
3. Click **Visit This Page**.

Group Name
DE-2-22

Entity Details

Entity

Entity Name	Unique Entity Code	Country	In Scope	Entity Status
AA GERMANY ROHAN	AA GERMANY ROHAN	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-3-33	DE-3-33	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-2-22	DE-2-22	Germany	Yes	Active
DE-1-11	DE-1-11	Germany	Yes	Active

Jurisdiction Country Details

Jurisdiction Country: Germany
VAT Number: DE1224543

VAT DEREGISTER **VISIT THIS PAGE**

Funding Bank Details

Here in the Jurisdiction Details page, you can set the Filer Type.

Group Name
DE-2-22 > Germany

Jurisdiction Details

Submitter Information

Filer Type: ☒ Entrepreneur ☐ Foreign Entrepreneur
☐ Tick if you are filing on your own behalf as an Entrepreneur

View Details

VAT Number: DE1224543
VAT Registration Type: [Dropdown]

Fixed Establishment Address Details

Street Number: [Text Field]
Street Name: [Text Field]

Fiscal Representative Details

Name: [Text Field]
VAT Number: [Text Field]

The options here are:

Filer Type	Description
Entrepreneur	A Tax Consultant filing for you.
Filing on your own behalf	You are filing on your own behalf.
Foreign Entrepreneur	A Foreign Tax Consultant is filing on your behalf.

Please note: By default, this section is set to **Entrepreneur**.

3.2. Changing the Default Submitter Type

If you change the submitter type, you must click Save at the bottom on the screen, at which point you will receive the following notification pop-ups.

3.2.1. File as an Entrepreneur on your own behalf:

The screenshot shows the 'Jurisdiction Details' form. The 'Entrepreneur' option is selected with a checkmark. Below it, the text 'Tick if you are filing on your own behalf as an Entrepreneur' is also checked. A red dashed arrow points from this text to a notification pop-up in the top right corner. The pop-up contains three messages: 'Successfully Updated Entity Jurisdiction Details', 'You have set your filing to file as an Entrepreneur on your own behalf', and 'Provide your certificate and PIN if you are filing electronically'. The bottom of the form shows sections for 'Fixed Establishment Address Details' and 'Fiscal Representative Details'.

3.2.2. Foreign Entrepreneur:

The screenshot shows the 'Jurisdiction Details' form. The 'Entrepreneur' option is unchecked, and the 'Foreign Entrepreneur' option is selected. A red dashed arrow points from the 'Foreign Entrepreneur' option to a notification pop-up in the top right corner. The pop-up contains three messages: 'Successfully Updated Entity Jurisdiction Details', 'Setting has been updated - you are filing as a Foreign Entrepreneur with a Fiscal Representative', and 'Complete your Fiscal Representative Details in Entity Jurisdiction Details'. The bottom of the form shows sections for 'Fixed Establishment Address Details' and 'Fiscal Representative Details'.

Please note: If you select the **Foreign Entrepreneur** option, then you are required to complete the **Fiscal Representative Details** section on screen.

☒ Foreign Entrepreneur

Fiscal Representative Details

Name

VAT Number

Street Number

Street Name

Line 2

Zip / Postal Code

City

State / Province / County

Country

3.3. Add PFX Certificate and PIN

What if no PFX Certificate/PIN has been added to your Entity?

In the case where neither a PFX Certificate and/or PIN have been added to your entity, then the following will be displayed on the return.

The screenshot displays the 'Return 145' interface. At the top, a table lists return details: Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Aug 2024), Status (Data Due), and Filing Deadline (2024-09-10). Below this, a notification box with a red border and a yellow warning icon contains the text: 'A Certificate file and a PIN is required to submit the return electronically. Please contact your administrator to add these details for filing electronically.' The interface also features tabs for 'Files', 'Data Validation', 'Transactions', 'Return Validation', and 'Return Review'. At the bottom, there are sections for 'Data Files', 'Output Files', and an 'UPLOAD ADDITIONAL FILES' button.

Please note: This Notification appears on all Statuses and for all user roles (Preparer/Reviewer/Approver).

In this scenario, the user has two options:

- Option 1: Open a JIRA Request
- Option 2: Submit It Manually

3.3.1. [Contact your TBI Representative](#)

Please contact your TBI Representative to have your PFX Certificate and PIN added to your Comply account.

TBI will provide you with an encrypted email link to securely send us the PFX Certificate and PIN/Password.

Once received, this will be added to your Comply account and the message will no longer be displayed on the returns screen.

3.3.2. [Submit it Manually](#)

If it is time sensitive, the user can elect to Process the Return and **Submit it Manually**.

1. Go to Return Review.
2. Download the XML file.
3. Log Into the Tax Authority Portal.
4. Upload the File.

4. Submitting

Once the return status in Comply is as “To Submit”:

1. Click **Submit**.

Return 210

Jurisdiction	Entity	Type	Frequency	Period	Status	Filing Deadline
Germany	DE-2-22	VAT Return	Monthly	Jun 2023	To Submit	2023-07-10

Next action due by 2023-07-10

Return Timeline • Audit History • 4 Comments • 0

Files Data Validation Transactions Return Validation Return Review

Return Boxes Submission Results

English Local language

Section	Description	Original Value	Submitted Value	Previous Period	Deviations	Previous Year	Attachments
Box 81 Net	Vat rate 19% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						
Box 81 Vat	Vat rate 19% (Tax)						
Box 86 Net	Vat rate 7% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						
Box 86 Vat	Vat rate 7% (Tax)						
Box 87	Vat rate of 0%						
Box 35	other Vat rates (Taxable Amount Without VAT)						

RETURN "TO PREPARE" CREATE RETURN BOXES VIEW RETURN SUBMIT

The return data is exchanged with ERiC via the API and goes through 2 Validation Steps:

- Authentication Process
- Data Validation

Please note: These are both Tax Authority processes.

4.1. Tax Authority Authentication

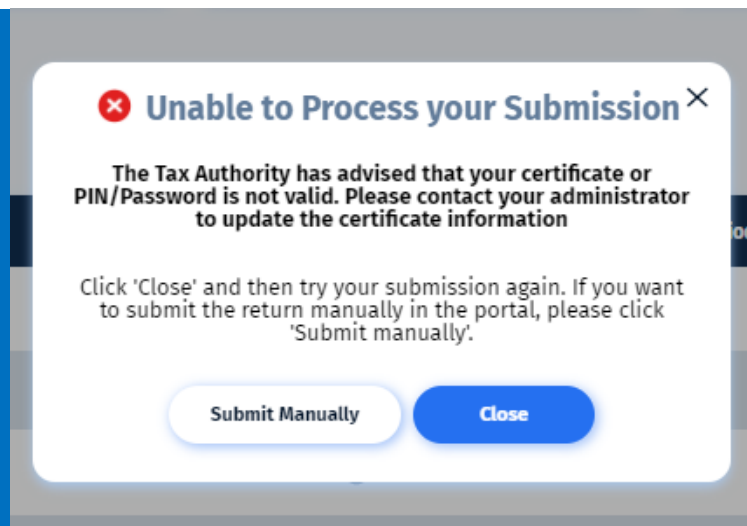
The Authentication process of your Certificate and Password combination is completed by the German Tax Authorities upon clicking the Submit button in Comply.

4.1.1. Authorisation Failed

An Invalid Certificate or PIN/Password were uploaded.

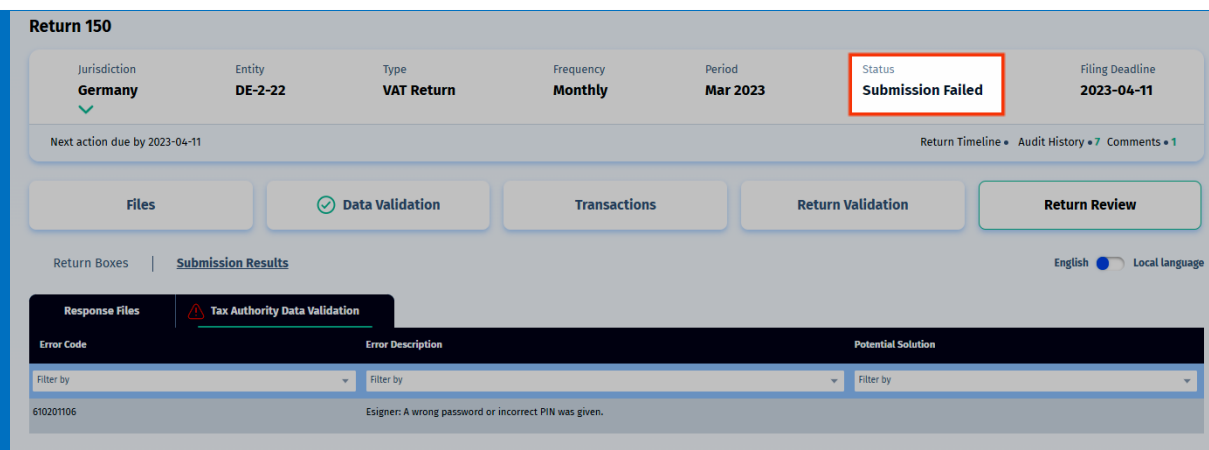
This triggers the following five things which happen simultaneously:

- **Error Pop-up**



- **Submission Status**

The Submission Status is changed to **Submission Failed**.



- **Submission Results**

The Submission Results tab is updated. In this example, the Tax Authority Data Validation tab displays an error icon, and the error is displayed below.

The screenshot shows the 'Return 150' page for a VAT Return in Germany. The status is 'Submission Failed' with a filing deadline of 2023-04-11. The 'Data Validation' tab is active, showing a red error icon and the text 'Tax Authority Data Validation'. Below this, a table lists error details:

Error Code	Error Description	Potential Solution
610201106	Esigner: A wrong password or incorrect PIN was given.	

- **Email Notification**

Any errors found during validation of the submission trigger an automatic email to the Preparer/Reviewer/Submitter.

The screenshot shows an email notification from Taxback International Support. The subject is 'Action Required: Certificate needs to be updated in Comply'. The email body contains the following text:

DE-2-22 / Germany

Dear Submitter,

Your certificate and PIN/Password in Comply is invalid. In order to submit your request electronically at Germany Tax Authority update this information and retry the submission.

Regards,
TBI Compliance team
[Support at Taxback International](#)

DISCLAIMER
Any delays in the provision of data or approval of summaries may result in penalties from the Tax Authorities. We cannot guarantee timely processing where late.
Any returns, summaries or reports prepared by Taxback International are based on the information provided to us. Any assumptions or adjustments made or in this e-mail or set out in our working papers. Whilst we may perform a review of the data and highlight potential issues, we do not accept any responsibility provided.

- **Audit History**

The Audit History is automatically updated with a Submission failed log.

The screenshot displays the 'Return 150' page in the Comply system. At the top, a header bar shows the 'Comply' logo and 'stoychevapp'. Below this, a summary bar contains fields for Jurisdiction (Germany), Entity (DE-2-22), Type (VAT Return), Frequency (Monthly), Period (Mar 2023), Status (Submission Failed), and Filing Deadline (2023-04-11). A message indicates 'Next action due by 2023-04-11'. Navigation links include 'Return Timeline', 'Audit History' (highlighted with a red box), and 'Comments • 1'. The 'AUDIT HISTORY' section features tabs for 'All Logs', 'Return Logs', and 'Transaction Logs'. A table below lists audit events with columns for Date, Event Group, Event Change (From/To), User, Comment, and Type. The first three rows of the table are highlighted with a red box, showing status changes from 'Submitting' to 'Submission Failed'.

Date	Event Group	Event Change From	Event Change To	User	Comment	Type
22/09/2023 13:44:06	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Passwort bzw. eine falsche PIN angegeben	Return
22/09/2023 13:44:02	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - Submitting	status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Passwort bzw. eine falsche PIN angegeben	Return
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - To Submit	status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
22/09/2023 12:51:44	Return Status Change	status - To Approve	status - To Submit	Keith O'Sullivan		Return
22/09/2023 12:51:40	Return Status Change	status - To Review	status - To Approve	Keith O'Sullivan		Return

4.1.2. Solutions

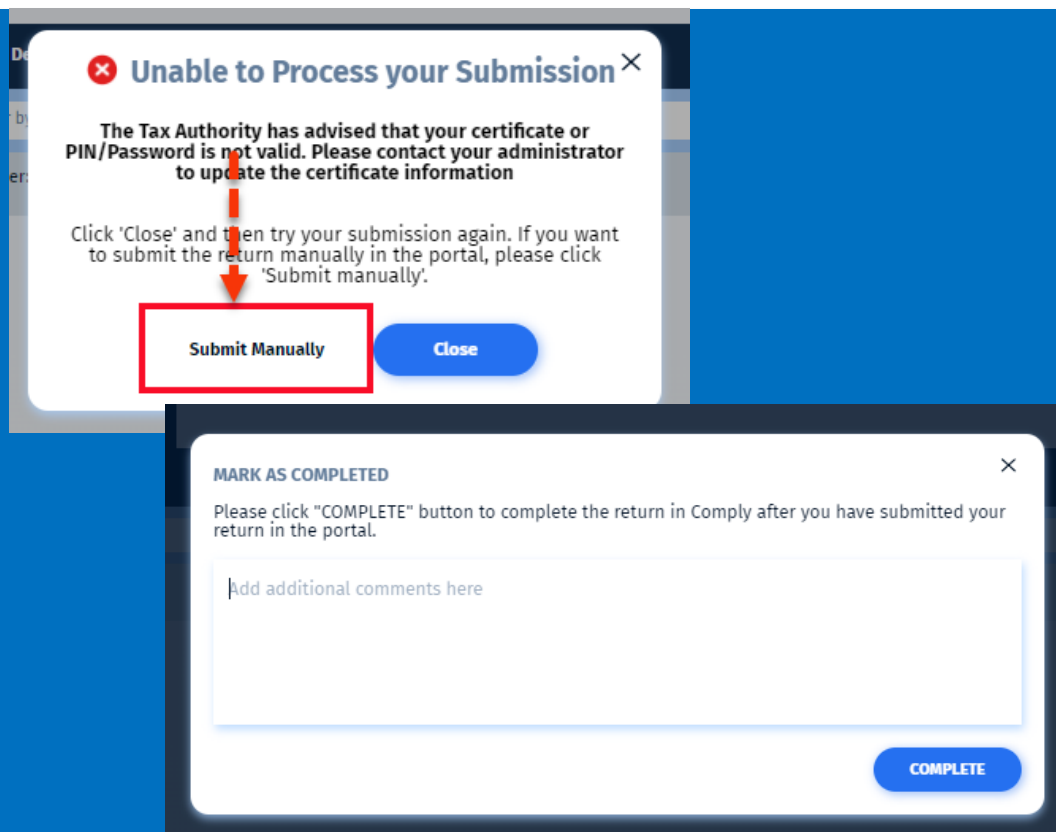
In this example, the user has two options:

- **Update Certificate/Password**
 1. Contact your TBI Representative/Open a ticket via the Client Engagement Desk.
 2. The following are required on the ticket:
 - CRM ID of Client
 - Client name
 3. You will be provided an encrypted email link to share the PFX Certificate and PIN.
 4. This will then be added to your account.
 5. You/Tax Consultant can submit the return.

- **Submit Manually**

This option allows the user to skip the API transmission and submit the return manually.

1. Click **Submit Manually**.
2. Go to Return Review.
3. Download the XML file.
4. Log Into the Tax Authority Portal.
5. Upload the File.
6. Click Complete.



4.2. Tax Authority Data Validation

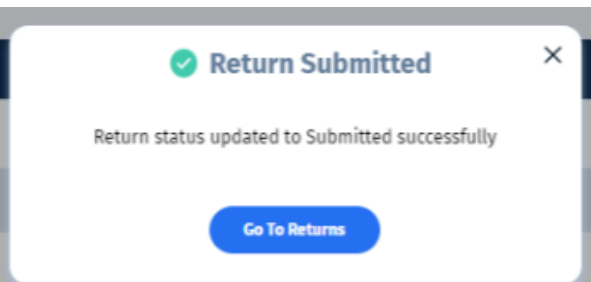
The Tax Authority validate the return against their own requirements. Depending on the result of this validation, the submission will be either:

- Confirmed as Successful
- Failed with an Error

In the case of a failed submission, an error will be displayed in **Tax Authority Data Validation** tab in **Submission Results** on Return Review.

4.2.1. Submitting Successfully

The following pop-up message is displayed when the return is filed successfully.

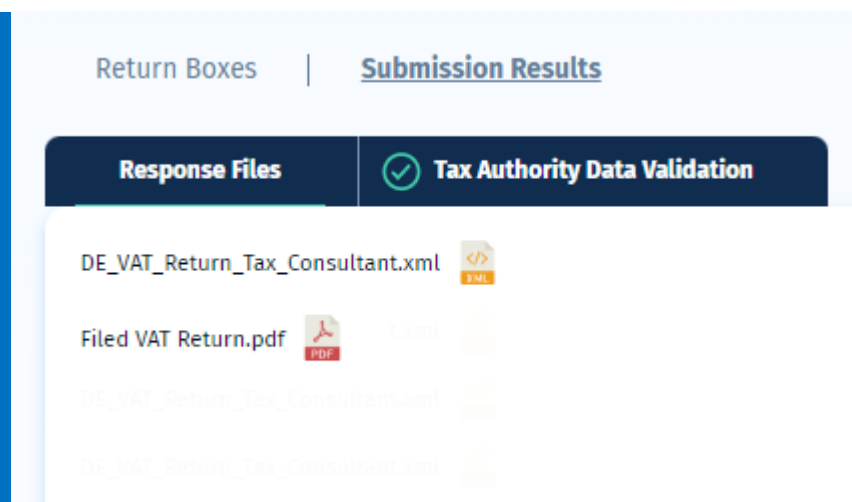


At this stage, the status on the return changes to “**Submitted.**” The **Go To Returns** button will direct the user back to the All Returns screen.

Submission Files Tab

Once a return has been successfully submitted, a PDF confirmation of the filed return will be populated in the Response Files Tab.

1. Click Submission Results.



2. Click Response Files.
3. Click the PDF Icon – This will include a label E.g., Filed VAT Return/Filed VIES Return etc.
4. Click the PDF (this will download the file)

Response File PDF v View Return PDF

The Response File PDF differs from the PDF stored in the VIEW RETURN section of Comply.

Location	Description
Response File	This is the successfully submitted PDF as produced by the Tax Authority
View Return Tab	This is the PDF produced by Comply, which is submitted to the Tax Authority (Before validation).

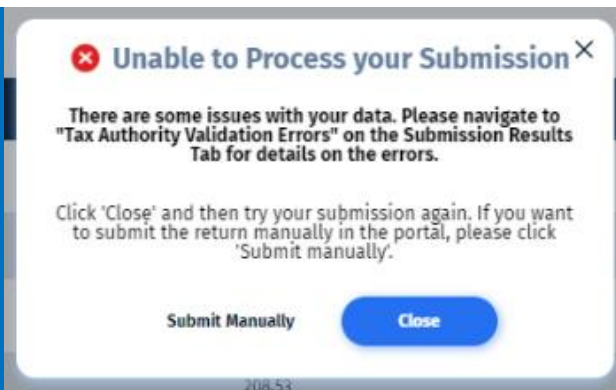
4.2.2. Failed Submission

There may be many reasons why the return fails the validation process, but in all cases, an error will be displayed on Comply explaining and providing basic instruction.

Several things will happen:

- **Error Message**

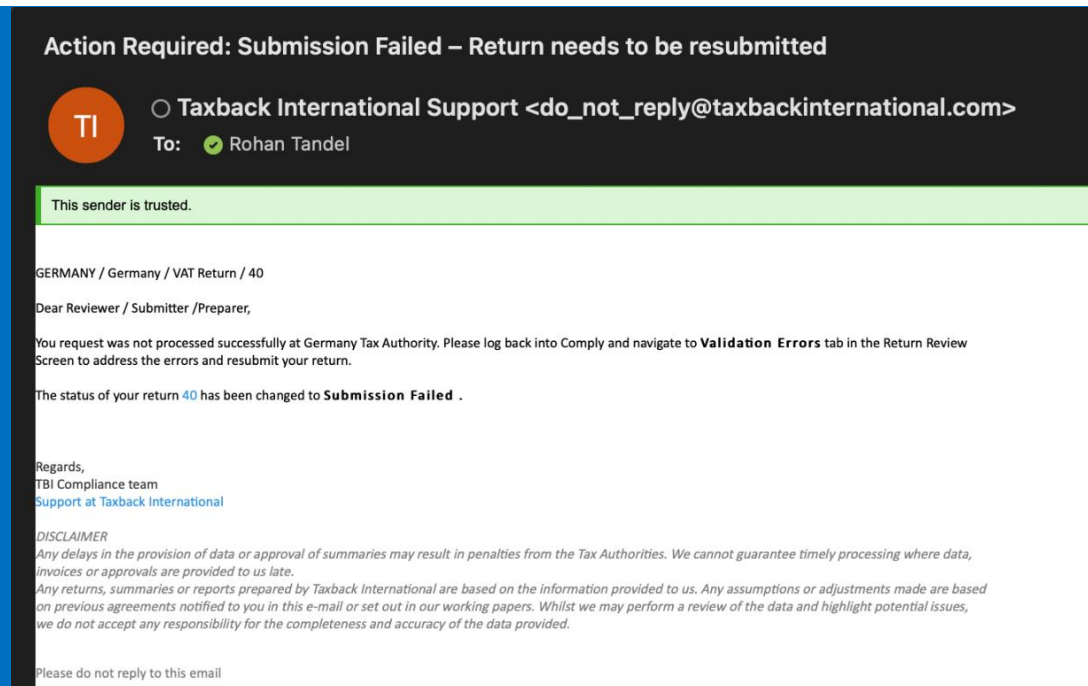
The following generic error will be displayed.



This message identifies that there are some issues with the data submitted which have failed the Tax Authorities Data Validation.

- Email

The following Email is sent to the Preparer/Reviewer/Submitter.

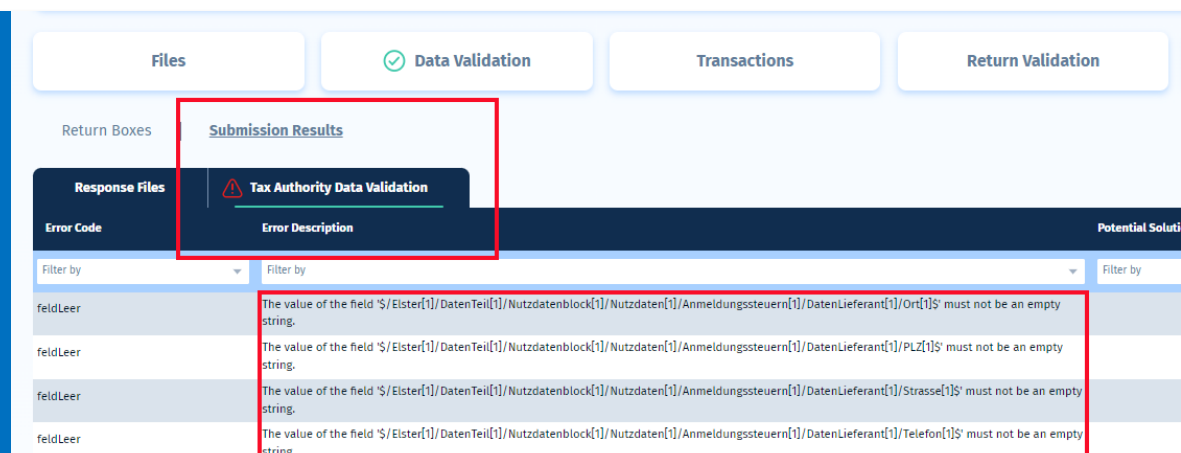


- **Submission Results**

A Validation result will be populated in Submission Results tab on the Return Review screen.

The Tax Authority Data Validation tab will display a red warning tag, and a new row will be added below outlining:

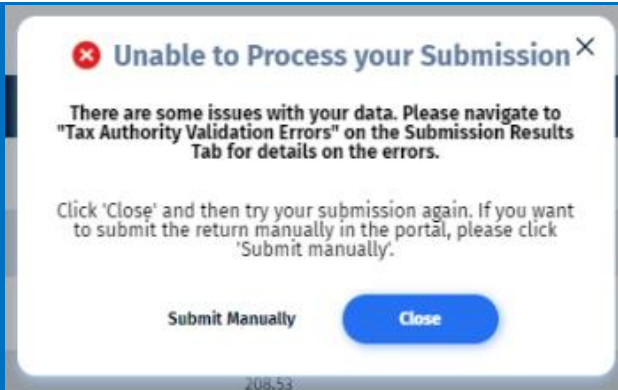
- Error Code
- Error Description



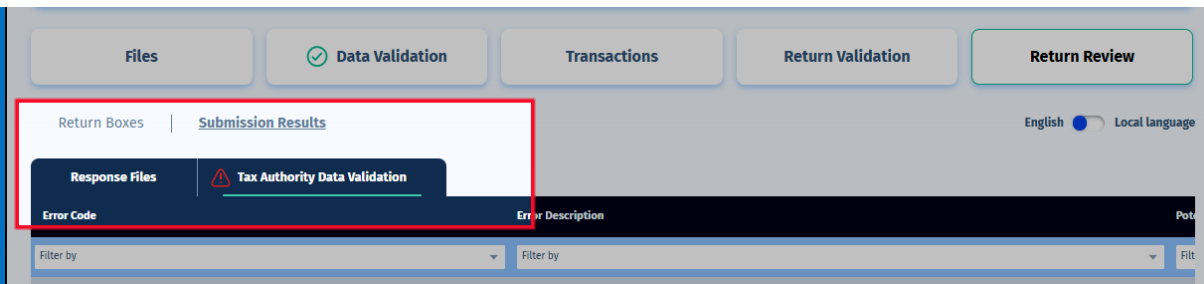
Solutions/Next Steps

There are two available next steps:

- Review the Data
1. Click **Close**. (the status remains on Submission Failed)



2. Click the Submission Results tab on Return Review.
3. Review the Error Description and Potential Solution.



4. Amend the data as required.
5. Resubmit (The Submit button is enabled on the Submission Failed screen.)

- Alternatively, Submit Manually submit to the Tax Office via the Portal.

1. Click **Submit It Manually**.
2. Go to Return Review.
3. Download the XML return file.
4. Login to the Tax Authority Portal.
5. Upload the XML file.

4.3. Return to “To Prepare”

If required, The Return to “To Prepare” button is displayed on the following Statuses:

- To Submit
- Submission Failed

Example: Submission Failed

Return 209

Jurisdiction Germany	Entity DE-2-22	Type VAT Return	Frequency Monthly	Period May 2023	Status Submission Failed	Filing Deadline 2023-06-12
--------------------------------	--------------------------	---------------------------	-----------------------------	---------------------------	------------------------------------	--------------------------------------

Next action due by 2023-06-12

Return Timeline • Audit History • 6 Comments • 0

Files Data Validation Transactions Return Validation Return Review

Return Boxes Submission Results English Local language

Section	Description	Original Value	Submitted Value	Previous Period	Deviations	Previous Year	Attachments
Box 81 Net	Vat rate 19% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	
Box 81 Vat	Vat rate 19% (Tax)	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	
Box 86 Net	Vat rate 7% (Taxable Amount Without VAT)	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	
Box 86 Vat	Vat rate 7% (Tax)	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	
Box 87	Vat rate of 0%	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	
Box 35	other Vat rates (Taxable Amount Without VAT)	0.00	0.00	0	0	0	

RETURN "TO PREPARE" CREATE RETURN BOXES VIEW RETURN SUBMIT

This will allow the user to bring the status back to “To Prepare” and make any relevant changes.

The user can then make the relevant changes, and process the return through the relevant return flow (To Prepare – To Review – To Approve – To Submit).

Frequency
Monthly

Period
May 2023

Status
To Prepare

Filing Deadline
2023-06-12

Return Timeline • Audit History • 7 Comments • 1

Transactions

Return Validation

Return Review

English ☒ Local language

	Previous Period ⓘ	Deviations ⓘ	Previous Year ⓘ	Attachments
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	
	0		0	

CREATE RETURN BOXES

VIEW RETURN

SEND FOR REVIEW

Once complete, the user can then Re-Submit the return.

5. Audit History

Once the user clicks Submit on a Return, Comply keeps an Audit History of each step in the process.

The screenshot displays the 'AUDIT HISTORY' section of the Comply API Submission (Germany) interface. The top summary bar shows the following details:

- Jurisdiction: Germany
- Entity: DE-2-22
- Type: VAT Return
- Frequency: Monthly
- Period: Mar 2023
- Status: Submission Failed
- Filing Deadline: 2023-04-11

Below the summary bar, the 'AUDIT HISTORY' section is active, showing a table of audit events. The table columns are: Date, Event Group, Event Change (From/To), User, and Comment. The events are as follows:

Date	Event Group	Event Change (From/To)	User	Comment
22/09/2023 13:44:06	Return Status Change	status - Submitting / status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa
22/09/2023 13:44:02	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed / status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - Submitting / status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa
22/09/2023 12:53:42	Return Status Change	status - To Submit / status - Submitting	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:44	Return Status Change	status - To Approve / status - To Submit	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:40	Return Status Change	status - To Review / status - To Approve	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:51:36	Return Status Change	status - To Prepare / status - To Review	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:50:52	Return Status Change	status - Submission Failed / status - To Prepare	Keith O'Sullivan	
22/09/2023 12:49:34	Return Status Change	status - Submitting / status - Submission Failed	Keith O'Sullivan	610201106 - eSigner: Es wurde ein falsches Pa

The interface also includes a 'Next action due by 2023-04-11' notification, a 'Return Timeline' link, and an 'Audit History' link (highlighted with a red dashed arrow). The table has pagination controls at the bottom, showing 'Prev', '1', 'Next', and 'View by 15, 30, 50'.

E.g., Each step is logged here automatically, including:

- The Date and Timestamp
- The change/process recorded
- The username
- The comment/description – this may include the error in case of a failed submission.